

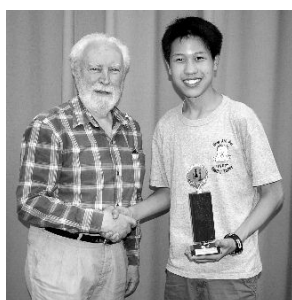
**AUSTRALIAN JUNIOR CHESS PROBLEM-SOLVING CHAMPIONSHIP
ADELAIDE, 10 January 2009**

Report, and Suggestions for the Future

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Solving in progress (one half of the hall). (A few solvers faced each other – not a good idea!)



Yita Choong presented by NN with the U18 open solving trophy.

(The above photos are courtesy of Cathy Rogers.)

1. This was the third year of the event, following Canberra 2007 and Sydney 2008. It has now been made an official Championship event, with trophies, and is required to be held each year.
2. The number of solvers was 40 (including two adults) out of about 100 players, thus about 40% participation. The rate has been about the same in each year. It is considered quite a good rate for the still somewhat novel event held on a rest day. Total entries were down this year, mainly due to a clash with the Australian Open tournament in Sydney. The entry fee was \$10.
3. Each solver was provided with a board and men. Most solved from the board and men, while a much smaller number solved from the diagrams. One solver had two boards set up, each with a different problem.
4. The time taken was noted when each question sheet was submitted, to be used if needed to break ties. It was scarcely needed this time. It might seem that the timing could be dispensed with, but it is important to make sure that Champions can be determined, ties not being

acceptable (playoffs are held to break ties in the playing events). Few competitors left particularly early, and quite a large number stayed for the whole time.

5. The questions and solutions, with diagrams, will probably be made available on the 2009 Championship's web site <http://www.sajuniorchess.org/AustJunior2009/index.html> or elsewhere. I also have plenty of spare copies on paper. The solutions are included at the end of this file (at reduced size to keep the file size OK for emailing – maybe view them with magnification).

6. I had prepared an article entitled “A Quick Introduction to Chess Problems and End-game Studies”, which was available on the 2007 Championship's web site http://www.actjcl.org.au/ausjuniors2007/section_puzzle.php and is still available there and is linked from the 2009 site. Just before solving started, I asked competitors whether they had read that article; regrettably, none had read it. If competitors had read that article, I believe the tasks would have been very much easier for many competitors, especially the younger competitors, and the marks gained would have increased. It is therefore strongly suggested for future such competitions that extra steps be taken to ensure that all competitors know in advance what problems and studies are, and that they have been exposed to a suitable introduction to them, with examples.

7. The format of the question sheet continues to work well: a single A3 sheet folded over to take up A4 size, with only the instructions on the front page so that the sheet could be placed unopened on the tables in advance. The word “Competitor” would best be removed from the front page. What might be most helpful there is: name, year of birth, boy/girl.

8. During the solving period I was available to answer questions from the competitors. Only a few questions were asked. The most common question was for the U10/8 paper: “how many moves do you have to write down for the studies?”. We had included the relevant instruction on the higher-age papers but not on the U10/8 one. After half an hour I realised that omission and made an announcement to all the solvers. Two had already left, so I later adjusted their marks for those tasks accordingly. The most amusing question was “I'm stuck on this one!”

9. Marking was carried out by Andy Sag and myself. We each marked each answer independently on marking sheets prepared in advance as blank sheets. It took several hours to enter all competitors' names with their sex (which is often not obvious from the first name) for each of the three papers and two ages within each paper. It was important to have the results ready for the presentation on the last day of the Championships, so about three days were available for marking, but various limitations of availability meant that less time could actually be used; nevertheless the marking was completed in time. One error of a clerical nature by each marker was resolved. The two markings differed very little generally, but small differences of partial credit were allowed to remain in cases where they did not affect prizes (the marks are averaged in the tables below). In the selection of tasks one should keep in mind easy marking, which was effective this time as before. The option which the competitors had of writing brief progress reports on unsolved tasks was taken up only a little and did not delay marking, but it seems unclear whether it need be included – for instance, any competitor not being able to solve a problem might well write down “the solution will be a move of the WQ”, if there is a WQ, because that is statistically the most likely key; a progress report allows a free guess.

10. I had assumed that the markers' job was finished when the total marks were reported and the orders indicated in each of the 12 age-group/sex sections. However, it should be made sure that the process of up-grading prizes takes place – for instance, a solver doing better than an apparently prize-winning solver in the higher age-group for the same paper should receive a prize in the higher group. That upgrading process takes place also in the playing competitions.

11. The list of prize-winners is available on the Championship web site <http://www.sajuniorchess.org/AustJunior2009/index.html> under "Draws and Games", and will probably be published in Australasian Chess and/or elsewhere. Many prizes were presented, including trophies for the top places in the Championship, subscriptions to Australasian Chess kindly donated by Brian Jones, a cash prize of \$150 for anyone scoring 100% kindly donated by Dennis Hale and awarded to Yita Choong of Western Australian (U18 Open) – at least, it is expected to be forwarded to him, for it was not available at the presentation – book orders, and a number of medallions purchased at the suggestion of parents. All entry fees were also included in the prize fund. The donations were not known until a few days before the event and will no doubt be acknowledged after the event. The prizes are greatly appreciated, and this event has since its beginning increased the likelihood of people going home happy. One family even delayed their interstate departure by a day in order to be at the presentation to receive a medallion for solving. Another mentioned that a similar prize for solving had been their only reward in Sydney 2008.

12. Very many thanks indeed are offered to Geoff Foster for carrying out the time-consuming job of setting the tasks and preparing the solutions. It is clear from the results, presented later in this report, that the range of difficulty of the tasks is now well suited to this competition. An instructive point learned, however, was that for the youngest solvers "mate in 1" may be more difficult than "mate in 2"! I mentioned this to Ian Rogers who commented "Well, the mates in 1 are certainly less game-like", and I think that's the essential point: that shortly after learning the game, it's naturally the game that is still best understood. Thus game-like tasks will be preferable in most cases for that age-group. Other types of questions (the whimsical type) could also be included in some sections, but that is subject to debate. It is best to make the tasks set as obscure as can be managed, so that no solver is likely to have seen them before; thus, although Troitsky's studies are incomparable, they might better be avoided here, though this is a matter for judgement

13. The question of the number of separate papers to set was discussed by several people. In Canberra we had just one paper placed unopened on all tables in advance, but in Sydney and Adelaide three. Three papers took some time to hand out; the solvers had been asked to distribute themselves so as not to be too close to others taking the same paper, so I had to ask each person what was their age group – the handing out took 15 minutes, so the time period became 10:15 to 12:15 (in Sydney it seems to have been 10:35 to 12:35). One suggestion was that, as the playing Championships are divided into U18 and U12, the same be done for the solving – thus just two papers. Another suggestion was that all papers be bundled together and given to all competitors – they can then answer whichever paper(s), or whichever tasks, they prefer. Another was to retain the present three papers. Another possibility is a single paper with the full range of difficulty increasing throughout – then the youngest solvers will expect just to work on the early ones, which will take only a little time for the older ones to solve. I also suspect it might be simpler to give the same number of marks for each task – just as players score 1 point for beating a player no matter what the opponent's rating is, the same

could apply in solving. Thus 15 tasks could be set with 5 marks each, all solvers being expected to start at the beginning and solve as many as they can. However, the wording would have to be considered carefully, for solvers might like to feel that they have a definite aim and a definite finishing point. Varied marks per task were introduced from the beginning in 2007 in order to make ties less likely, but the experience meanwhile seems to suggest that ties are unlikely to be a serious problem in any case, especially considering the use of partial credit. Yet more marks for harder tasks would result in imposing a smaller penalty on an advanced solver who slips up on an easier task. All this is of course to be considered further before next year's event.

14. Adults were invited this time, via a local newspaper – a good idea in my opinion – although only two took part they were very welcome and I'd be glad to see this continued. Whether solving competitions will ever be tried in local adult events remains to be seen.

15. The general impression from their comments was that competitors enjoyed the event. The administrators also seemed very satisfied with it. All comments heard were positive. One of the adult solvers came up to me when the event ended, ecstatic over the King-Parks #2 (1.Bh1); he had written "1.Bh1!!"(I too find it very attractive).

16. I asked an excellent young solver how it came about that he was so good at this – he answered that his coach gave him at least three to solve each week. In my short presentation speech I suggested that competitors might ask their coaches to include some problems and studies, as indeed some coaches already do.

Some Statistics of the Marks (Please see the Tables below.)

17. It should be borne in mind that the competitors had unfortunately not read the specially prepared article "A Quick Introduction to Chess Problems and End-game Studies" referred to earlier: that reduced the value of the competition and the significance of the marks, especially for younger competitors, and the marks gained should be interpreted accordingly. In any case, no disparagement was ever intended towards those scoring low marks.

18. The marks scored have meaning only in relation to the particular tasks set and their difficulty, so that comparisons from year to year, or to school-work exams, would not have full validity. The relationship between the percentage marks scored and the difficulty as estimated in advance (according to the maximum marks allotted to each task) was observed to a fair extent (see Table 3). One of the main departures was the difficulty of the two Mate in 1 tasks in U10/8, mentioned earlier. The tendency for studies to be better solved than problems, which had been observed in Canberra 2007, was not particularly noticed here. The comparison of tasks set in more than one paper (see the asterisks in Table 3) showed little difference between U18/16 and U14/12, and that between U14/12 and U10/8 showed inconsistency, the Greco study being a little harder for U14/12 but the Liburkin one much easier.

Best wishes for the future!

Nigel Nettheim, 16 February 2009

Table 1. Number of Competitors, for each Year of Birth and each Sex

A = Adults

Year	91	92	93	94	95	96	97	98	99	00	01	A	Total
Male	0	2	2	1	4	2	3	5	3	0	4	2	28
Female	1	0	2	2	0	1	4	0	1	0	1	0	12
Total	1	2	4	3	4	3	7	5	4	0	5	2	40

Table 2. Number of Competitors who took each Age/Sex paper

Two boys aged 9 took both the U10 and the U14 papers within the 2-hour period.
One boy aged 13 took only the U18/16 paper. The two adults took the U18/16 paper.

Year	U18/16	U14/12	U10/8	Total
Male	6+2A	15	7	28+2A
Female	5	5	2	12
Total	11+2A	20	9	40+2A

Table 3. Percent of Total Marks Scored, for each Task on each Paper

Results for males and females are combined here. The tasks will be made available as mentioned earlier. Maximum marks obtainable are shown in parentheses; each cell shows the percent of these awarded (not absolute marks). Adults are included here. The same task in different sections is indicated by [*] etc..

	U18/16		U14/12		U10/8	
	Task (Max)	%	Task (Max)	%	Task (Max)	%
1	#2 Rice 1.Kg3 (5) [*]	85	#2 Rice 1.Kg3 (5) [*]	83	#1 Anon 1.Nb4 (5)	33
2	#2 Rowland 1.e4 (6)	85	Win Greco [**] 1.Kf4 (7)	32	#1 Anon 1.c3 (5)	33
3	Win Pogosyants 1.b6 (7) [****]	65	#2 Nielsen 1.Bc6 (7)	65	#2 Rice 1.Kg3 (8) [*]	75
4	#2 Somma 1.Qf4 (7)	43	Draw Liburkin 1.Kh2 (8) [***]	65	Win Pogosyants 1.Kd6+ (8)	54
5	#2 King-Parks 1.Bh1 (7)	47	#2 Voronov 1.Qh1 (8)	48	Win Greco 1.Kf4 (8) [**]	46
6	Win Heuacker 1.Ba7 (8)	61	Win Bodoïn 1.Rh6+ (8)	52	Win Anon 1.a6 (8)	49
7	Draw Afek 1.g7+ (9)	56	#2 Hernitz 1.Qb8 (9)	67	Draw Anon 1.c7 (9)	43
8	Win Moravec 1.c7 (9)	56	Win Galinsky 1.Ne6+ (9)	64	Win Bianchetti 1.d5 (9)	44
9	#2 Kovacevic 1.Bf5 (10)	54	#2 Sushkov 1.Kd6 (9)	56	Draw Liburkin 1.Kh2 (10) [***]	19
10	#2 Rossomakho 1.Nd2 (10)	69	#2 Kubbel 1.Qc6 (10)	79	#2 Pankratiev 1.Qf7 (10)	56
11	#3 Andrade 1.Qg8 (11)	15	Win Pogosyants 1.b6 (10) [****]	62	#2 Voronov 1.Qh1 (10)	22
12	Win Troitsky 1.Qd4+ (11)	34	#2 Niemeijer & H 1.Qa8 (10)	46	#2 Sushkov 1.Kd6 (10)	31
	Total (100)	53	Total (100)	57	Total (100)	42